Being the governor of the Reserve Bank would, of course, be a great honour and privilege, an exciting opportunity to steer the macroeconomic management of the country. There was hardly any need to think through further; the decision seemed straightforward. I immediately thanked Chidambaram for putting my name on the shortlist and requested him to take my candidature forward. I don't think he was surprised by my enthusiastic response but added for good measure that the prime minister wanted him to explicitly check with me since I was in line to be the next Cabinet secretary.

With the big issue settled, we quickly moved into settling the logistics. He asked me what time my flight was, which unsurprisingly for a West-bound international flight out of India was in the middle of the night. 'Could you then,' he asked, 'come to my house at 8 p.m. for a chat with Dr Rangarajan and myself? Rakesh is coming in at 7 p.m.' Dr C. Rangarajan is a former RBI governor and at that time was chairman of the prime minister's Economic Advisory Council.

I had a heavy schedule for the day stretching late into the evening, including a briefing session on the forthcoming G20 meeting agenda with my staff. On top of that, I now had to make space for this interview. I called up Urmila, my wife, and told her. Her reaction was typically nonchalant. 'If that's what you want, I wish you all the best.' Her only advice was that I call up Rakesh and level with him on this development. I could not reach him all through the day.

Several times during the day, it did cross my mind if I was being interviewed as a pro forma candidate just to build up the paperwork to show that the government did indeed consider a panel of candidates before making a final choice. That would be handy if the decision came under the scrutiny of any of the watchdogs, including the media. But I dismissed the thought because Chidambaram was too professional to do something like that. Besides, in the course of the day, I was not handed any formal notice of interview; no paper trail was being established.

By the time I showed up for the 'interview' at Chidambaram's house, I was exhausted but neither anxious nor tense. Coincidentally, the